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POL317: Comparative Public Policy and Administration

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Question (Week 1, May 7): *“To what extent do behavioural and emotional models displace rational choice as a general theory of political action, as opposed to operating as bounded corrections within it?”*

The preferences that people hold in their minds are the state of the world they desire. Politics is fundamentally about people disagreeing, which would not be possible if people did not have different preferences. People's preferences can only be measured ordinally, which means that they can be ranked but the relative distance between the ranks cannot be measured (which would be cardinality). Rational choice theory analyzes how people maximize utility when they make decisions. While no one is omnipotent, and therefore not capable of making fully rational decisions, people still try to maximize their utility with the imperfect information that they have, even if they could have made a more optimal decision. Political action preferences can relate directly to formal institutions, such as deciding which candidate to vote for in an election, or to less formal institutions such as deciding to attend a protest.

It can be very difficult for people's political action preferences to be revealed as it is institutionalized in many cultures to view them as being very private and almost all country's electoral regimes involve a secret ballot. Collective preferences are often revealed through the results of elections and pre-election opinion polling surveys. Although, this is to a certain confidence level as not everyone in a significantly large group of people votes in every election and responds to every survey. However, it can be argued that "groups, classes, firms, and nation-states do not have minds and thus cannot be said to have preferences" (Shepsle, 1997). I personally do not agree with this view since groups of people do have minds that work together to form preferences, just not one mind.

As virtually nothing is certain in life, there is inherent uncertainty and therefore also risk involved in making decisions, including political action decisions. Uncertainty and risk also influence people's preferences and therefore decisions in rational choice theory. According to the Von Neumann–Morgenstern utility theorem, expected utility can be calculated by the probability of an outcome multiplied by the payout if that outcome does occur. For example, someone could calculate based on statistical simulations of polling data, that candidate A has a very low chance of winning but will cause a very high payout and candidate B has a very high chance of winning but will cause a very low payout. Additionally, while maximizing utility is self-interested, political action decisions affect other people, so it is possible for a person to gain utility from believing that other people are also gaining utility. Finally, risk tolerance preference also varies greatly by person, which could cause someone with a preference for higher risk to choose candidate A and lower risk to choose candidate B. Changing the status quo is also intrinsically risky, so someone with a higher risk tolerance would likely prefer change while someone with a low risk tolerance would likely oppose change.

Emotional and behavioral models can operate within or fully displace quantifiable rational choices. Unlike a very measurable payout, such as a tax cut that causes an increase in an individual's disposable income, the utility from experiencing an emotion can be very difficult to quantify as it is inherently abstract. This could be roughly measured by asking the individual how much they would be willing to pay to experience that emotion. Emotional models within rational choice theory also include time discounting, as people generally have a preference for utility in the present rather than in the future (Wilson, 2011).

How choices are framed can fully displace people's rational choices (Tversky and Kahneman, 1981), which is common in politics due to propaganda. For example, people value losses more than gains, so framing one option as a loss and the other as a gain, even though they both provide the same utility, can cause preferences when they rationally should be indifferent. Similarly, emotions such as anger can cause "lower risk perceptions" and "riskier judgements" (Pierce, 2021), which is changing people's decisions without directly providing utility. Emotions can cause someone to not even do the process of making a rational choice and only follow their emotions instead.

In conclusion, rational choice theory is vital to understanding people's political action decisions. Behavioral and emotional models operate both within and fully displace rational choice decision making, as emotions themselves cause utility but also distort rationality. This concept is important for people to understand when making political action decisions, as politics is fundamentally about disagreements which often cause emotions, and this can make it more challenging for people to maximize their utility.

References

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